

An illustration on the left side of the page depicts the goddess Metis in three different forms. At the top, she is shown as a woman with long, dark, wavy hair, looking down. Below her is a red bird with a yellow beak. At the bottom is a yellow lioness. To the right of the lioness is a small, light brown deer. The background is white with numerous thin, radiating lines and small pink star-like symbols. The title 'The Birth of Athena' is written in a large, elegant, black serif font at the top right.

The Birth of Athena

Metis, the goddess of advice, had helped Zeus free his siblings from the stomach of his father, Cronos. She was also very beautiful, and Zeus had fallen in love with her.

Metis, however, did not feel the same way about Zeus. She tried to avoid him by transforming into various different animals—first a bird, then a lion, then a deer, and so on. Zeus eventually caught up with her when she was in her human form, however. Soon Metis became pregnant.

Meanwhile, Gaia, goddess of the Earth, had made a prophecy that any son born to Metis would one day overthrow Zeus, just as he had overthrown Cronos before him. This worried Zeus.

Inspired by his father, Zeus decided to swallow Metis whole, along with their unborn baby.

“This way,” Zeus thought smugly, “Gaia’s prophecy can’t possibly come true.”

Nine months later, however, Zeus was struck by a headache so strong that it felt as if the Cyclopes themselves were hammering at his skull.